Arab unemployment, Eastern exploitation

Another example of the periphery's misadventures can be found in the Arab world. The political upheaval which has rocked this region for the past three years emerged from multiple causes. But one thing is for sure, several decades of furious neoliberalism created poverty, stagnation and inequality and this triggered the explosion. The region has suffered record unemployment, partially disguised by its rentier regimes' practice of distributing handouts. But privatisation and labour flexibility have generated large-scale social fractures.[32] Pressures to reduce social spending and eliminate food subsidies pushed millions of youth in the Middle East into losing hope. They could not survive in their own countries and were forced to emigrate to Europe. These dispossessed ignited the revolts when a Tunisian vendor set himself on fire to protest prohibitions on selling in the streets.[33]

Like Africa, this region enjoyed a brief period in which nationalism flourished in the 1960s. This experience ran aground because of the inability of these processes to eradicate the parasitical domination of the big capitalists. Neoliberalism subsequently aggravated an explosive combination of underdevelopment and rentierism.[34]

A third case of regression on the periphery can be found among some Asian nations which have not participated in the expansionary wave generated by China and the intermediate economies. This zone has suffered terrible indices of multi-dimensional poverty as measured by the United Nations Development Programme. Its last report emphasised that 51% of the global population which suffers from extreme misery lives in South Asia and 15% alone live in the east of this continent. Yet such a high level of poverty is becoming a magnet for multinational companies seeking new supplies of cheap labour, and labour-intensive sectors, such as textiles, are an important barometer of this trend.[35]

In the 1970s, the first wave of offshoring of clothing manufactures settled in Korea, Taiwan, Singapore and Hong Kong. The second move came in the 1980s, landing in Indonesia, Sri Lanka, the Philippines, Bangladesh and Thailand. In recent decades, a third flow has reached Cambodia, Laos, Burma and Bangladesh. The most famous brand names impose frightening levels of super-exploitation on their workers. A major international protest campaign under the banner 'Clean Clothes' is denouncing the atrocities that predominate in these workshops.

An example of this drama came to life in Bangladesh. There, the GDP has grown consistently since the 1990s, converting the country into the third-biggest clothing exporter in the world with 4 000 factories, employing three million workers. These employees work between 12 and 14 hours a day, breathing in dust